

Contents

1	"My body feels like it's coming off"	1
1.1	draft	1
1.1.1	the scene	1
1.1.2	the method	3
1.1.3	the outputs	5
1.1.4	toward erotics	12
1.2	sketches	13
1.2.1	reverse outline	13
1.2.2	questions	14
1.2.3	Naomi's notes:	14
1.2.4	outline	15
1.2.5	bank	15
1.3	notes	21
1.3.1	outputs	21
1.3.2	sketches	33
1.3.3	some theory:	34
1.3.4	transcript analysis	35
1.3.5	reading notes	36
1.3.6	cutouts from drafts	41

1 "My body feels like it's coming off"

1.1 draft

1.1.1 the scene

In a reality TV show called *Love is Blind*, an American couple, Paul and Micah, visit a cenote in Mexico. Micah notices a school of fish, and she recoils:

Micah: Is that a shark?

Paul: What do you mean shark? Oh, they're catfish. They look like baby, like, tiny nurse sharks.

Micah: Okay, this is kind of scaring me. It's my worst nightmare if one touches me.

Paul: These little catfish?

Micah: Yeah.

Paul: You're not their mommy.

FIND EPISODE

Paul and Micah have agreed to get married, but they only just met in person a day or so ago. Before that, they had been talking for several days through a wall, getting to know each other and falling in love without ever having seen each other. Once they agreed to marry, the rules of the show go, they are allowed to meet in person—a meeting that typically marks when the relationship starts to fall apart. For Paul and Micah, theirs will last all the way until the wedding day, when Paul rejects Micah directly on the altar. The reason, he later explains, is because he "struggled with... envisioning Micah as, like, you know, a mother" (EPISODE).

In the show, participants share the desire to be "loved for who I am on the inside," (Season 2, Episode 3). This declaration recalls not only the show's central gambit, that "love is blind," but also signals a transgressive premise that undergirds the ultimately heteronormative plot. Despite a teleology that ends in marriage, something non-normative is happening here. And that something has to do with the body, and what happens to the body and its desire when it falls in love behind a wall.

The focus of my study is how the experience of embodiment affects normative desire in cisgendered subjects. I take readings of normativity from Trans Studies and apply them to an analysis of cisgendered subjects from the show. What does this dating situation, where visual access to the beloved is denied, do to the self-perception of the body of the participants? I find that this "blind" dating experiment places participants in a state where their own bodily coherence fractures, which has consequences on their larger romantic trajectory in the show. While firmly anchored to their cisgendered identities, the participants undergo a split in the physical body, which begins to accrue investments in integrity and wholeness that inevitably go unfulfilled once they are united with their beloveds. Through this process, I argue, they enter a temporary version of what Jay Prosser calls the "transsexual trajectory," characterized by a desire for "assimilation", or a sense of "belonging the body and the world" (59). Reading their experience through this trajectory opens bodily experience and erotics as a potential vector of solidarity, one that flows through and between subjects, in spite of what Prosser describes as their "location" on in the journey toward desire fulfillment (FIND QUOTE).

1.1.2 the method

To surface this trajectory in *LiB*, I use a reading method that synthesizes details of the dating experience into common patterns. Using the transcripts from the show, I created a text generator that mimics the speech of the participants. I chose this method because it abstracts from specific examples—the transcripts of the show—to synthesize common and shared investments in language. It allows me to study language in a "normalized" form, which I explain in more detail below.

I also chose this method in attempt to push against dominant uses of machine learning technology. Amid what Emily Bender and Alex Hanna call this "AI hype bubble," it is important to explore applications of machine learning that are not environmentally devastating or extractive as commercial-level models developed by the tech monopolies (FIND AI HYPE QUOTE). The model for this project is a fraction of the size of the commercial models that run applications like ChatGPT, meaning the hardware, electricity, and data used for developing and running the model are miniscule in comparison, and can be carried out on a single laptop.¹

Using this technology as a tool for analysis and critique, I harness its predictive features in order to study language use and patterns. The current emphasis on productivity, while serving extractive and monetizing purposes, misses the fact that these tools are primarily *self-reflexive*. As Wendy Chun points out, predictive tools might be used to discover and study existing patterns in data, rather than simply generate more content for the sake of productivity. She compares common machine learning applications, like those that drive ChatGPT, with climate change models, and asks,

How can we treat machine learning systems and their predictions like those for global climate change? These models offer us the most probable future given past and current actions, not so that we will accept their predictions are inevitable, but rather so we will use them to help change the future. (26)

Applying prediction to *LiB* transcripts, this project takes Chun's point one step further: prediction, in addition to being a descriptive mechanism, is

¹For example, this project uses GPT-2, which is initially trained off only 8 million web-pages and released under an open license. Compare that with the most recent version of GPT, GPT-5, which is trained on something like the entire internet and is over 600 billion parameters in size, a number that cannot be confirmed due to its closed and proprietary status. While the training process for my model took less than an hour, and was all done on my single Mac laptop, commercial-level models require multiple rounds and massive computer "clusters," containing hundreds to thousands of GPUs, and months of training.

a normalizing one. Within the prediction process itself, there are protocols that regularize language expression, finding and amplifying frequent patterns of word usage. From repeated phrasings and frequent words in the show transcripts, this method distills or "normalizes" the dominant tendencies and perspectives embedded within the show.

Because prediction is, in other words, "an ideal tool for studying normativity. For example, when asked about love, the model will generate examples like:

Love is really important to me.

Love is what I need in my life.

Love is everything that I've been looking for.

None of these examples actually appear in the transcripts of the show. In fact, in the transcripts, the only examples of sentences that begin with "Love is" is, perhaps predictably, followed by the word "blind." The second half of these sentences, then, are not filled by verbatim extracts of text of the show: rather, they are filled in by phrases that appear in similar contexts or are closely associated with the word "Love" in the transcripts. Instead of reproducing verbatim expressions, then, the model generates approximations and patterns of expressions within the transcripts.

But how does the model know which words are closely associated? In the model's internal representation, each word is represented by a definition, a definition that consists of a long list of numbers, or probabilities. Within this long list of probabilities, each individual probability score represents that word's relationship to *another word* in the dataset. For the model, then, that word is represented and defined by a chain of these probability scores, which correlate that word's relationship to a chain of other words in the dataset. So, in a kind of literalization of the poststructuralist floating signifier, a single word is understood as, not what it means in itself, but how it relates to (and differs from) every single other word. Using these lists of probabilities, a model will then generate words that are most likely to appear together.

In order to compile these probability scores, however, the model must first be trained on a dataset, such as the transcripts of the show. First, the model takes a sample sentence from the transcript, like "Love is blind," and it blocks out the second half of the sentence, so that only "Love is" remains. It tries to guess which word or phrase should go in that second half. Because the model has no idea what the words mean, the guess will be wrong. Then, it checks its prediction against the actual sentence. Because the guess is

inevitably wrong, there will always be a difference between the prediction and the actual result. And this is when the model starts to compile its list of probabilities, keeping track of which words tend to appear with each other in context. The more that certain words appear together or in similar contexts, the higher the probability score between those two words. Each time that the model makes a subsequent guess, it updates its internal representation of the word to reflect its probable association (or lack of association) to certain words.

It will make guess after guess, trying out many words, perhaps every word in the dataset, until it is sure of those that are most likely to appear together. With each guess, the model makes *very slight* adjustments to its own representation of word meaning (this constant iteration, and the computer processing required to do it, is why language models take lots of time, energy, and computer hardware to train). By the end, the list of probabilities will reflect a kind of average of that word's association to other words.

Coming back to the example, "Love is blind," the model will ascertain possible completions for "blind," given other words that are associated with "love" in the dataset. One completion it gives, "really important to me," reflects these associations in action. For example, in the actual transcript of the show, this phrase "really important" appears in the following excerpt: "I have a great career, I have a condo, and the one thing I've been missing is finding someone to share all that with. And that's a really important reason why I'm here" (FIND EPISODE). This means that in the model's internal representation, the phrases "great career," "condo," and "someone to share it with" have already been associated—either directly or through a relation to another word—with that of "love." Unsurprisingly, given the heteronormative nature of the dataset, happens, these are all words that have to do with long-term commitment. So the model will input a phrase that also appears in this context, such as "really important," and use that phrase to complete the prompt, "love is."

I read this associative mechanism as a kind of *approximation* or *normalization* of language. The model generates language by approximating what is most likely, most plausible, based on its training data. As such, it is ideal for studying shared perceptions and attachments by the characters on the show.

1.1.3 the outputs

The show contains two stages, the pre-engagement stage, where participants date each other from separate "pods" where they can hear but not see the

other, and engagement stage, where participants finally meet and proceed to live together in preparation for the wedding. In partitioning the romantic experiment into pre-engagement and engagement segments, the show poses the presence and role of the body as the variable that ultimately determines the viability of long-term commitment. In other words, it sets up an examination of how the body may affect normative trajectories and desires.

To explore the differences between these periods of the show, I trained two separate models on each of these periods: the first model is trained on the transcripts from the pods episodes, and I call it the "pods model"; the second model is trained on the episodes following the pods, and I call it the "postpods model."

Then, I prompted both models with input phrases about the body and touch to see how each of them would respond individually to the prompts.

When prompted with phrases like "When I touch you," and "Physical touch is," and "Physically," (See Appendices 1 & 2 for a full list of prompts), the pods model generates the following outputs:

When I touch you, I feel it.

When I touch you, I feel your energy, and it is, like, I'm just so happy.

When I touch you, I can feel your soul, your heart, and your soul aligning so well.

When I touch you, I feel you, and I feel you, I feel you, and I feel you.

Physical touch is important to me.

Physical touch is the most important thing.

Physical touch is so sexy.

Physical touch is like a glove.

Physically, we are so happy.

Repetitions in outputs like, "When I touch you, I feel you, and I feel you, I feel you, and I feel you," are expected behavior in text generation models, especially those that are small and relatively underdeveloped, like this one. Because the model generates what is most likely, sometimes, it will get stuck in loops, repeating the same phrase over and over again. This quirk reinforces the predictive nature of the model, which will generate what is most

plausible.²

The rest of the results, then, reflect what is most plausible given the information from the training data, the transcripts. Considering that they are based on a period of the show when no actual touching occurs between the couples, it makes sense that the model would associate touch to non-tangible aspects like "soul" and "energy." It also makes sense that touch is elevated as something highly desired, to an "important," "most important," and even "sexy" quality, because that is what is being foreclosed from during this period of the dating experiment. Finally, the last two examples, "like a glove" and "we are so happy," suggest an association between touch and compatability, in the sense that the couples "fit" together, so to speak.

The outputs with those from the postpods model, however, put touch in very different contexts:

When I touch you, I feel like I'm in my head.
When I touch you, you just feel like it's so weird.
When I touch you, it feels like a jab.
When I touch you, like, I feel like I'm literally in my head.
When I touch you, it feels like something I'm about to get up
and walk away.
When I touch you, I feel like it's like I've just, like, left the room.
When I touch you, the thing that's scary is, like, it's a physical
thing.
When I touch you, you're like "I'm blinking."

Unlike the pods model, these outputs present touch as a not pleasant experience. Touch is "so weird," "like a jab," and associated with workds like "scary" and "physical," suggesting a strange and even disruptive aspect to touch. Touch also seems to signal movement in relation to location, "in my head," "walk away," and "left the room." While in the pods, touch drew the characters together, evoking non-tangible phenomena like the soul and energy, here it seems that touch pulls characters from their own bodies and each other.

²While models are good at predition, they are not at all good at being creative, at innovating. A model can only generate what it has already seen before. Even a phenomenon like "hallucination," that a model spews text that has no bearing in reality, is based on the tendency of models to repeat what they've already seen. They hallucinate not because they are creative or random, but because they are designed from statistical processes to produce what is most plausible rather than most accurate.

What is really interesting about these outputs is how a mistake in the prediction process reveals something about touch's relationship to the other senses. The phrase that says, "I'm blinking," is actually taken directly from the show, and is an example of an undesired but not uncommon blip in the prediction process. In machine learning, this blip is referred to as "overfitting," when a verbatim section of text from the training data, in this case, the show transcripts, is generated in the output. "Overfitting" means that the model is *too* accurate: that it has slipped from making predictions that are plausible to repeating exactly the data it has been trained on. A model overfitting in its outputs is generally a sign that there isn't enough training data or enough variation in the training data, meaning that the model has less examples from which to approximate and generalize. So it resorts to simply reproducing direct examples from its training.

For my purposes, however, overfitting is not only a blip, it also points to a tension the sensory modes of touch and sight, which emerges in a specific scene in the show. The original reference to "blinking" appears in the first meeting between a newly engaged couple, Zach and Irina:

Zach: Do I look like what you thought I'd look like?

Irina: I had no guesses of what you looked like.

Zach: Oh!

Irina: You have, like, the blindest stare in your eyes.

Zach: Really?

Irina: I'm just kind of taking it all in.

Zach: Me too.

Irina: You look like a fictional character. You look like something out of a cartoon.

Zach: I know.

Irina: You have to blink!

Zach: I am blinking.

Irina: You don't blink. You look like this.

Zach: I am blinking. I will try not to be too intense. *Season 4, Episode 4, "Playing with Fire"*

When Zach and Irina meet, it is clear that both are reacting to the reality of each other's physical form in their own ways, with Irina, in particular, asking Zach to adjust his behavior, "to blink!" Blinking is, of course, a way

of stopping the entry of visual data, of occluding it from perception. For Irina, the request for Zach to blink might indicate own sense of overwhelm at his physical form, at his sudden incorporation before her eyes. The visual reality of him takes her by surprise, and perhaps proves too much. Projecting her own feelings of overstimulation, perhaps, she asks him to blink.

Following the story of Zach and Irina, it becomes clear that the catalyst for their breakup is a lack of physical attraction on the part of Irina. Later in the same episode, Irina explains her feelings to Micah, who is coupled with Paul.

Irina: And so, Zack. I feel like is my type on paper. Has, like, brown hair, brown eyes, like, chiseled face. Like, I really like dark features. And the moment I saw Zack, it was like, "I don't know who this man is." And I was like, "Maybe it's just scary, and it was a lot." Like, hopefully it's gonna grow, but I've noticed every time he does, like, touch me, I get, like, major ick. When he puts his arm around me at night, I literally was like— like, my heart stopped. And I literally go. . . But not, like, in an excited way.

Micah: I wanna, like, relate to you in a way, but it's always, like, so different.

Irina: How was it with you and Paul?

Micah: The thing with me and Paul is, like, we both, like, had such an immediate understanding as best friends.

Irina: Yeah, Paul's gorgeous.

Zach supposedly has physical aspects which Irina finds attractive, "brown eyes, chiseled face," but something about him nonetheless repulses her. At his touch, she recoils, "get[ting]. . . major ick." While she claims her lack of attraction to Zach is not determined by his appearance, Irina simultaneously elevates the importance of visual appearance with the phrase, "Yeah, Paul's gorgeous." Which begs the question: if Irina finds both Zach and Paul visually attractive, then, what repulses her about Zach?

The answer could be a number of things, which Irina may or may not have revealed in the course of the show. But the point is not the specific reason. Rather, it's that the model made a connection between touch and "blinking." This connection leads to a scene where the visual sense overwhelms and may even occlude the other senses, such as touch, which is a result of the experience of the characters in the pods. It suggests that there is something about the foreclosure of the visual sense in the pods which Irina,

and perhaps other characters, want to carry with them when they leave the pods, "blinking."

Sequestered from the sight of the other within the pods, the participants experience a kind of bodily split in which their own physical senses materialize in new and surprising ways. They experience not only the physical body, the material reality of their physical body which they've always known, but also what Jay Prosser refers to as the "body image," an internal but no less material perception of the body. According to Prosser, "body image—which we might be tempted to align with the imaginary—clearly has a material force for transsexuals" (69). For trans subjects, this "material force" often manifests in the trope of being "trapped in the wrong body" and feelings of dysphoria.

For these cisgendered subjects, I argue, this force manifests in a heightened sensation of the body, which paradoxically creates a feeling of the body's dissolution. When prompted with the phrase "My body," the pods model generates the following completions:

My body feels like it's coming off.

My body feels heavier.

My body feels so different now.

My body feels weird.

My body makes me feel like it's real.

My body feels torn between two different people.

At the moment where visual access to the other's body is denied, there is an increased sensing of one's own physicality. The body comes into apprehension in a novel and visceral way, which makes the body seem all the more strange. The body feels "weird" and "so different now" because it is not the same body as that which also had access to the visual sense. This new body is "heavier," more "real," weighted with its new awareness that is almost super-real. Perhaps the reference to being "torn between two different people" evokes just their prospective matches, but to a single person with two bodies which are in tension. As Prosser explains, the body image creates "conflict between the true body within and the false body without, between sentient body image and insentient visible body" (70). For the straight cisgendered folks within the pods, this may have been the first (and only) time to any divergence between the material and imagined bodies.

But it is not a feeling that lasts long: in the postpods model, the body appears to be re-integrated. Here, the language about the body shifts into notably more visual and positive descriptions:

My body is gorgeous.
My body is so cute.
My body is so pretty.
My body makes me feel lighter, more confident.
My body makes me feel warm.
My body makes me feel like I've missed my train.

The outputs address the body in concise and visually flattering terms: the body is "gorgeous," "so cute," "pretty" (Appendix 2, "My body"). Perhaps, now that the couples can see each other, the body feels "lighter" and "warm," suggesting coherence where before there was weight and weirdness. Despite this coherence, however, there is a lingering feeling of loss: "My body makes me feel like I've missed my train." This statement, with its slightly nostalgic undertone, suggests that even when coherence is gained, something is lost.

What is lost comes into view when the model is prompted with statements about physical touch:

Physical touch is everything that I've ever wanted in a partner.
Physical touch is everything that I've wanted in a wife.
Physical touch is a big part of what I want.
Physically, there's so much potential here.
Physically, it was the perfect opportunity.

Physical touch is described in aspirational terms: it is "everything I've wanted," not "everything I got." The traces of present perfect and past tense to discuss "want" is indicative: even after meeting in person, their desire remains unfulfilled. The restoration of the visual sense, the re-integration the fractured body image, then, does not offer completion or culmination.

Being restored their visual sense heals the *LiB* participants from the bodily split, but it does not save them from the aftermath of their investments. Although they exited from one trajectory, what Prosser calls the "route to bodily integrity," they remain stuck with the desire for a kind of touch that is "everything that I've ever wanted in a partner." Due to their experience in the pods, the significance of touch has been inflated to include other, perhaps practically unattainable, desires. Considering that the characters are now reunited with their physical bodies, there is something almost cruel in this denouement, a "cruel optimism," in Lauren Berlant's formulation,

which describes the attachment that drives desire even while it wears out the desirer.

Perhaps touch is evoked as aspirational because, even before the bodily split, the participants had formed attachments to a romantic love that transcends physical barriers, to a love that is "blind." Then, when they enter the pods, the foreclosure of one sense perception amplifies the embodied sense, splitting what was once a coherent bodily wholeness. This new body image emerges seemingly from nowhere, fed by hope from behind the wall. Subsequently, when the couples finally meet in physical forms, they remain plagued by the possibilities for physical connection that they felt in the pods. And these expectations are what, for some of them, prevents their ability to accept their partners as they are.

More specific to their bodily predicaments, then, the characters perhaps experience a version of what Hil Malatino describes as "future fatigue" (20). Like cruel optimism, future fatigue generates "intense anticipatory anxiety" that "impede[s] flourishing" (Malatino 20). Unlike cruel optimism, however, future fatigue concerns trans subjects who are invested in "the promised moment of harmony between the felt and the perceived body" (Malatino 27). Despite being cisgendered, these subjects in *LiB* undergo a disruption of bodily integrity when they enter the pods. It is in that context that they develop their romantic feelings. Most of them, when they leave the pods, cannot sustain this romantic connection—a very physical connection—into their fully embodied lives.

1.1.4 toward erotics

Malatino theorizes "future fatigue" as a foundational affect that moves from frustration and failure to read moments of potential and connection among trans subjects. I am not interested in applying, even I could, readings of "of looseness and possibility, not yet overcoded and fixed in meaning, signification, or representative economy" for these *LiB* subjects (32). After all, cis-hetero significations and dynamics are already well represented and coded. What I am interested in, rather, is in surfacing some vectors of connection between cis and trans experience.

I believe that this reading approach, which seeks out what is common and shared among identity groups, can help push back on the polarization that characterizes the current discourse about trans rights in the USA. And I know this because I began this study with the goal of analyzing transphobia directly. I gathered datasets from conservative magazines and anti-trans legislation, and used those sources to train my machine learning models. I

thought machine learning, with its tendency to amplify what is most frequent, might reveal something about transphobia's attachment to certain norms and ideals.

As I got deeper and deeper into transphobia, however, I realized that perhaps I was working with the wrong data. That I should shift my attention to desire, rather than fear. Because desire, the erotic, I sense, has more potential for finding connection and forging solidarity.

And Trans Studies offers no dearth of theorizing on erotics, of studies of the body, between Malatino's "felt and perceived bodies" and Prosser's "material body" and "body image," and what this does to desire in belonging (CITE). Trans Studies does a good job of explaining how, in Prosser's words, "'feeling like' can be experienced as a core self" (75).

I close with a final question on the potential of erotics by Cassius Adair. In his study for t4t erotics, he asks, "Why can't the erotic be a site of producing trans identity or practices?" He points out that, after all, cis people do it all the time: they use sexuality and sexual encounters as sites of identity formation."

1.2 sketches

1.2.1 reverse outline

- This paper is about normativity
 - Sedgwick on reading practices
- Looking at the body in cisgender narrative, the body dissociations
- Using a method to study normativity that *normalizes* language.
 - **ADD: language is first quantified**
 - at each step, representations are adjusted
 - meaning is averaged
- close reading:
 - created two models, trained on different parts of the show
 - in the pods, touch evokes non-tangible phenomena
 - out of the pods, touch pulls characters from place and body
 - out of the pods, the visual sense overwhelms the other senses, "blinking"

- in the pods, "my body" splits into dissociation/newness
- out of the pods, body signals visibility
- out of the pods, left with aspiration that affects touch
- characters left with aspiration for touch at the end
 - **ADD: example of touch being terrifying, "you're not their mommy"**
 - perhaps something left over from the pods that places them in a state of something like future fatigue
- Reading practices as a way of working against transphobia.

1.2.2 questions

Are there, could there be, any way of surfacing body narratives in heterosexual, cisgendered stories?

How might these investments connect the anti-trans and trans perspectives?

Machine learning ideal tool for studying normativity: a tool for finding the shared, the average, the obvious.

Close reading analysis:

- Question – how does the presence of the visual body affect dating?
- Answer – body perception splits, bodily sensation flows and ebbs.

1.2.3 Naomi's notes:

- Reader must be invested in the reading method.
- The technical process is a heuristic.
- Add a few sentences summarizing the technical process before going into details.
- Scene setting in the beginning. The tendencies of language.

1.2.4 outline

- toward a new method of reading
 - AIDs crisis: what kind of knowledge can help deveop politics.
 - reading normativity, looking for shared investments.
- close reading: machine learning
 - the training process toward approximation
 - hallucination and overfitting (when there isn't enough data)
- close reading: LiB
 - person splits from visual in the pod
 - * Prosser on body image split from material body
 - * "my body" activates sensorium of feelings
 - * touch is more direct?
 - postpods,
 - * the body collapses into the visual
 - * touch becomes repulsive
 - * future fatigue sets in
- trans studies on normativity
 - Chu: requires that we understand normativity
 - Prosser: on narratives of embodiment, coming back to the body
 - Malatino: attachments to the future

1.2.5 bank

Over 25 years ago, in response to lack of government response to the AIDS crisis, Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick questions the point of knowledge practices like critique. She asks, "What does knowledge do—the pursuit of it, the having and expressing of it?" (124). In a moment of incontrovertible evidence of government disregard (if not disdain) for those affected by the AIDS crisis, primarily Black and gay lives, Sedgwick wonders about the point of doing critique in the first place. It seems that, at that moment in time, no level of exposure or demystification would "enjoin on [...] persons to any specific train of epistemological or narrative consequences" (123).

One could apply this question to our political situation now, with more than enough evidence documenting the level of neglect of and contempt for trans people in the US. Furthermore, the technological evolution puts all the damning evidence at our fingertips, to amplify the message to what is, for many of us, anxiety-inducing levels.

This paper proposes a reading practice that responds to this particular political and technological moment of information overload and impotence, and it explores one possibility for what we might do with it. It seeks out, like Sedgwick did decades ago, a way of reading that surfaces connections in places where they are unexpected.

Despite being cisgendered, then, body image can have a material force in an environment where the integrity bodily perception is disrupted. The sensation of the body feeling "real" and like it's "coming off" speak to this process of fragmentation, a process that is so visceral so that, as Prosser explains, "feeling like... can be experienced as a core self" (79).

This is how it builds a sense of the meaning associated with each word,

So that the that the model "learns" how characters talk about certain topics like love, desire, and the body.

This paper is about normativity, and how the desire for normativity can connect even the most polarized subjects and experiences.

Participants enter *Love Is Blind* with one goal: to find their ideal partner and get married. However, the show's main gambit is that the participants cannot see each other; they must date from behind a wall, with only access to the other's voice. Once they have agreed to get married, then they are allowed to meet their intended in person. And usually, that is when things start to go south.

1. some outputs

I've had a lot of weight on my shoulders. I'm a very passionate person. I'm excited to spend my first night with her. I'm so excited to talk to you. I think that I'm falling in love with you too. I've fallen in love. I'm just so scared. I've been feeling really good about it.

I'm really happy for you. I'm just gonna have to... I think that, like, we can work through it and, like, move it to where we need it to be. I think so. I love it. I'm happy you got me all the way through the loop. I don't know. I don't want you to get hurt.

The future with you, it's gonna be tenfold. The future togetherness is gonna be great. The future with her, she's gonna be there forever.

The future looks pretty bleak. The future has been absolutely horrible. The future, like, relationships with her are gonna be very intense.

2. postpods: touch is my worst nightmare Looking at the transcripts, touch is associated with revulsion. In this example, the couple Paul and Micah encounter some fish in the ocean.

Much more negative than the touch happening in the pods.

3. no sex In the context of the show, these outputs make sense because physical intimacy begins to plague most the couples as soon as they meet. As they move from the pods to living together, they struggle to progress their relationships into physical contact, a fact that is mostly kept unacknowledged until there is breakup.

4. THE FUTURE BECOMES BLEAK

(a) in pods, excitement for union/commitment PODS

- I'm excited to spend my first night with her.
- I am so excited to spend the rest of my life with you.

POSTPODS

- I think that, like, we can work through it and, like, move it to where we need it to be.
- I don't want you to get hurt.

(b) future is positive, becomes negative/bleak In pods, the future is positive:

- The future with you, it's gonna be tenfold.
- The future togetherness is gonna be great.
- The future with her, she's gonna be there forever.

Postpods, the future is more negative:

- The future looks pretty bleak. (repeated)
- The future has been absolutely horrible.

5. what does LiB have to do with trans studies? Strictly speaking, I do not align with the identity qualities that determine belonging in either of the groups that I am concerning myself with in this essay. As a cis lesbian, who is not trans, and who is not straight, where do I come off making a case about using Trans Studies theory to read the dynamics of heterosexual relationships? I could say that queerness puts me into a kind of solidarity/intimacy with trans subjects, or even that

my sexuality is intimately linked to my more masc presentation. But that is as true as it would be to say that I experience a foundational connection to cis subjects through the shared identification with my assignment at birth—which is false.

6. trans studies on normativity, body splits, future fatigue To explore the desire for normativity, I borrow from ideas in Trans Studies. Andrea Long Chu points out that Trans Studies "requires that we understand—as we never have before—what it means to be attached to a norm, by desire, by habit, by survival" ("After Trans Studies" 108).

Specifically, I borrow from ideas about the body. I am interested in how the body figures into trajectories of normativity, which, in the case of the cis-hetero subjects in *LiB*, is about the trajectory toward getting married.

And that this experience tells us a lot about what normativity, how the desire for normative markers, works in perhaps unexpected intra-social ways (that it creates envy and animosity among cis groups?). The experience for cis subjects in the pods creates expectations and disappointments that are actually shared across identity groups.

7. word vectors First, I feed examples of text culled from the show's transcripts into . It then uses these patterns from the text to make educated guesses on how to respond to questions about the body and its role in the couples' romantic plot. This process, which is highly technical (and explained in detail below), allows me to surface common perspectives and experiences from the characters on the show. It is a tool for normalizing language expression into average forms.

I use computational tools, which translate word semantics into numerical representations, that can then be converted into averages (explained in technical detail below). I then generate the most average expressions based on this text, expressions that explore concepts of embodiment and desire and how they influence normativity.

I choose this computational method because it is an ideal one for studying what words and phrases mean base on the context that they are being used. This method, which is machine learning, aggregates word meaning from various examples of usage. For my project, these examples come from the transcripts of the show itself, which I feed into a machine learning algorithm. This algorithm "learns" what words mean in context. It's goal is build a strong enough model of word meaning

so it can then make accurate predictions of what words tend to be used together in a sentence.

There are some technical concepts that are essential to understanding how this predictive process works.

First, one must understand how language is represented in numerical forms, which are called word vectors. Word vectors are how a machine learning knows what words mean individually, they comprise the model's internal dictionary, so to speak. Drawing from the concept of "vector" in math, which describes coordinates for a line in graphical space, word vector consists of numbers, a long list of numbers. For example, below is the word vector for the word "queen":

'queen': -0.3583, -0.6767, 0.1689, -0.6164, -0.0135, -0.2284,
0.3359, 0.1149, -0.1512, -0.8014

Each of these numbers following "queen" (e.g. .3583, -0.6767, 0.1689, and so on) represents the relationship between queen and another word, like "woman" or "orange." Each of those numbers represents this relationship as a probability score, a percentage that indicates how closely those two words are associated with each other. In this database, the words "Queen" and "woman" would likely have a high probability association, due to their both being associated with humans and femininity, while "woman" and "orange" may have a much lower probability. Therefore, in vector space, the multi-dimensional space where the words are plotted as lines, the coordinates that represent "woman" would be nearby the coordinates that represent "Queen," and farther from the coordinates that represent "orange."

Vectors transform what we think of as word meaning by quantifying it into a numerical representation. And the idea is that once word meaning is quantified, it can be calculated. The matrix format of the word vector enables a host of mathematical operations and algorithms: from example, cosine similarity calculates the distance between two vectors, that is, two words; and regression analysis guesses the relationship between an independent and dependent variable, or relation between one word and another.

Word meaning, significantly, can be calculated via a formula. That's what the authors argue, anyway, in the paper that introduced word vectors to the world, titled "Efficient Estimation of Word Representations in Vector Space" (Mikolov et al. 2013). To illustrate the power

of word vectors, the authors offer calculate the vector "queen" by subtracting "man" from "king" and adding "woman."³

`vector('King') - vector('Man') + vector('Woman') = vector("Queen")`

This example was presumably chosen for its intelligibility, based on operands whose differences are assumed to be stable across cultures. To get "queen", one need only add "woman" to "king", and from the resulting sum, subtract "man." The meaning of each term appears to be self-evident and universally true; it is stabilized by the equals sign that balances the formula. That readers know what a "man" and "woman" are, just as they know what a "king" and "queen" is, speaks to how assumptions of gender are implicated within those of patriarchy and imperialism.⁴

8. training process

In the first step, the "hypothesis" step, a model will randomly guess what words are associated with each other—it will make a hypothesis. In doing so, it takes a sample sentence from the transcript, like "Love is blind," and it blocks out the second half of the sentence, so that "Love is" remains. Then, it tries to guess which word or phrase should go in that blank. Because the model has no idea what the words mean, the guess will be wrong. But that's doesn't matter, because the purpose of the hypothesis is to make any guess, so that it has something from which it build in the future steps.

After making this guess, it moves to the next step, where the machine checks its prediction against the actual example. Because the guess will be inevitably wrong, there will always be a difference between the prediction and the actual result. And it will calculate the difference between the prediction and the actual example, which is called the "loss."

From this difference, this "loss," it starts to build a sense of contexts associated with each word, keeping track of which words tend to appear with each other in context. Each time that the model makes a subsequent guess, it updates its internal representation of the word to reflect its association (or lack of association) to certain words. In

³Mikolov et al.

⁴I am always astounded at how computer scientists tend to use examples based on gender to illustrate mathematical intuition.

technical terms, this internal representation of the word is called its "word vector," called so because it contains a long lists of numbers, the "vector," which represents the word's meaning to the model.

In the third step, it moves to the minimizing this "loss" by *very slightly* adjusting the contents of the word vector. The model will do this many times, so progress is very slow, but also very precise. It will make guess after guess, trying out many words, perhaps every word in the dataset, until it finds those which are most likely to appear together. This constant iteration, and the computer processing required to do it, is why language models take lots of time, energy, and computer hardware to train. At each round of training, the vector attached to each words is slightly adjusted toward what is effectively a vector that accurately represents that words' relationship to every other word in the database.

1.3 notes

1.3.1 outputs

1. BODY EMBODIED -> MULTI-SENSORY / IDEALIZED

(a) **DONE** in pods, being loved on the inside PODS

- I want someone who is gonna have the most authentic relationship and the most authentic connection with me.
- I want someone who will love me regardless of how I look, not my bad breath.

(b) **DONE** in pods, body is more embodied, becomes visual Like a second skin, like a weight: heavier, reality, different, torn, but also like an open mind, going all over my mind.

After pods, "like I've missed my train".

PODS

- My body, like, tingles.
- My body language is, like, obviously very masculine.
- My body image is perfect.
- My body image has definitely been, like, a lot more superficial for me in my own way.
- My body language is so fluid, and my voice is so calm.
- My body language is so weird, but I don't really know what to do.
- My body language is so weird!

- My body language is, like, very controlling.
- My body language is just, like, very relaxed.
- My body makes me feel like it's real.
- My body makes me feel like it's going all over my mind.
- My body feels weird.
- My body feels heavier.
- My body feels so different now.
- My body feels like it's coming off.
- My body feels torn between two different people.
- My body feels like it's always an open mind.

POSTPODS

- My body is so, like, tight and, like, tight.
- My body is very, very physical.
- My body is gorgeous.
- My body is so cute.
- My body is so pretty, you know.
- My body is gorgeous, and my soul is so beautiful.
- My body is so pretty, but my heart is so pretty, you know.
- My body, you know, I'm not sure if I would fit in here.
- My body makes me feel like I've missed my train.
- My body makes me feel uncomfortable.
- My body makes me feel so, like, so, like, so, like, vulnerable.
- My body makes me feel so icky.
- My body makes me feel like I can be more aggressive, more aggressive.

- (c) touching goes from feeling good to multi-sensory, emotional feelings When close reading the examples of "touch", in PODS they are all positive and forward looking; and in POSTPODS they are mostly negative and describe revulsion.

In the LLM, in the pods, touch is brought to the present and is positive, and for the postpods, touch expands to different senses.

PODS

- Touching you Touching me, I'm just so happy.
- Touching you touch me.
- Touching you touch, you know, just, like, touching.

- Touching you Touching me feels good.
- Touching you Touching me is just amazing.
- Touching you Touching me feels nice.
- Touching you Touching me feels great.
- Touching you Touching me feels good.
- Touching you know, touching you.
- Touching you touch, seeing you touch.
- Touching you touch is so sexy.
- Touching you Touching me Good.

POSTPODS

- Touching you with my voice, you're not blinking.
- Touching you and your soul with everything that's happened.
- Touching you, I felt the connection that we had.
- Touching you, I feel like we're in a perfect spot.
- Touching you, I literally feel like I'm in love.
- Touching you, I'm getting a little emotional.
- Touching you is everything I've ever wanted.
- Touching you like that, we're ready.
- Touching you, I feel like I'm ready.
- Touching you is my wish.

(d) touch ambivalence in postpods: I want to touch you / I don't want to touch you PODS

- I want to touch the couch.
- I want to touch somebody.
- I don't want to touch him, but I want to be his wife.
- I don't want to touch him.
- I don't want to touch anyone's feet.
- I don't want to touch my feelings.

POSTPODS

- I want to touch you/him/her (repeated for all).
- I don't want to touch you/him/her (repeated for all).

2. INTIMACY BECOMES ASPIRATIONAL; SEX BECOMES SCARY

(a) intimacy is physical, becomes aspirational PODS - more descriptive, fearful though hopeful

- Being intimate with you just makes me feel so safe.
- Being intimate with you has made me feel so connected to you.
- Being intimate with you has made me feel so alive.
- Being intimate with you feels so sexy.
- Being intimate is very sexy, but I don't wanna put on a lot of body image.
- Being intimate is fun.
- Being intimate is good.
- Being intimate is so sexy, and I've never felt so close, so deep, so deep.
- Being intimate is definitely very attractive, and it makes me feel so safe and secure.
- Being intimate, it's so easy to get to know someone and be vulnerable.
- Being intimate, it's very physical.
- Being intimate has been very exciting.-
- Intimacy is one of the biggest things I'm constantly insecure about.
- Intimacy is definitely a fear.
- Intimacy is not worth it for me.
- Intimacy is not my thing.

POSTPODS Intimacy described as desired but deferred:

- Being intimate with you is something that I've wanted for my entire life.
- Being intimate with you is something that I've never experienced.
- Being intimate with you is something that I've wanted for my whole life.
- Being intimate with you is something that I could potentially do.
- Being intimate with you is the most sacred thing.
- Being intimate with you is really meaningful.
- Being intimate with you is something that I need.

- Being intimate with you is a big deal.
 - Being intimate with you is one of the most important things to me.
 - Being intimate with you is something that I've been looking for since day one.
 - Being intimate with you is very rare for me.
- (b) sex begins ambivalent, becomes denounced/feared PODS
- Sex is important, but can be difficult and fearful
- Sex is definitely important to me.
 - Sex is fucked.
 - Sex is definitely important.
 - Sex is scary.
 - Making love is scary.
 - Sex is a lot.
 - Sex is sexy.
 - Making love is hard.
 - Making love is not easy, but it's important.
 - Making love is not easy, but it's worth it.
 - Having sex is not something that I would ever wish on anyone else
 - Making love is a real thing.
 - Making love is, like, very real.

Feels like it's a consolation? Like explaining why someone won't be having sex, or speaking of sex as a hypothetical

- Having sex is a thing, like, I don't wanna make you feel like that.
- Having sex is not a thing to anyone's tastes.
- Having sex is not a thing to anyone's mind, you know.
- Having sex is still taboo, it's still very much a thing.
- Having sex is a thing, I do have a huge amount of freckles.
- Having sex is hard for me, and I just feel like it's not worth it.
- Having sex is a physical act, and I'm not attracted to physical attraction

Ambivalence :

- Having sex is sexy, but there's something about it that I don't want to put my finger on.
- Having sex is something that I am very attracted to, but it is also something that I am not attracted to
- Having sex is sexy, it's fun, and I've never even seen a woman having sex with me.)
- Having sex is not something I would want in a partner, but it's something I can definitely do.

Sex for reproductive/mating reasons.

- I want to have sex because I want to have kids.
- I want to have sex because I feel like I'm the complete package.
- I want to have sex because I want to be with somebody who is, like, doing that.

POSTPODS: the physical body introduces a problem.

Sex becomes a problem, posing an obstacle or fear

- Having sex is a thing.
- Having sex is a thing, right?
- Having sex is not a normal thing, you know.
- Having sex is not a normal thing for a couple.
- Sex is a very, very, very, very, very serious thing.
- Sex is definitely a factor.
- Sex is a big part of my life.
- I prefer not to have sex with him, but I'm gonna have sex with him.
- Having sex is a big deal for me, but it's not something that I could ever do.
- Sex is something that I should never ever do.
- Having sex is so easy, and it's really scary.
- Having sex is a very scary step.
- Sex is a very, very, very, very scary, very, very real fear.
- I prefer not to be affectionate.

Sex for intimacy reasons

- I want to have sex because I feel like I'm ready to have it.
- I want to have sex because I feel that I'm attracted to you.

- I want to have sex because I'm nervous.
- I want to have sex because I love you.
- I want to have sex because I feel like it's gonna be, like, really fun.
- I want to have sex because I feel like I've never had sex before.
- I want to have sex because, like, I'm not sacrificing what I want.

3. others

- (a) don't want sex I don't want to have sex because I feel like I'm making the wrong choice. I don't want to have sex because I feel like I'm attracted to Josh. I don't want to have sex because I feel like I have sex with her. I don't want to have sex because I feel like I'm in love with you. I don't want to have sex because I don't want sex. I don't want to have sex because... I don't want to have sex because I don't want you to be having a lot of sex. I don't want to have sex because of my mom. I don't want to have sex because I don't wanna have sex. I don't want to have sex because I feel like I don't want sex with him. I don't want to have sex because I want a lot of sex. I don't want to have sex because I feel like I'm trying to make the most of my life. I don't want to have sex because I feel like I'm questioning him. I don't want to have sex because I don't know how to describe that. I don't want to have sex because I feel like I'm in love with you.
- (b) natural In the pods, it feels natural to be present and communicating in an intimate way, but outside of the pods, what appears to be natural is lifelong commitment.

PODS

- It's natural that I'm here.
- It's natural that I've been so deep with you.
- It's natural that I feel comfortable enough saying that.
- It's natural that you're in a position to be treated differently.
- It's natural that I'm in it.
- It's natural that I feel like I have to be with somebody that's not there for me.
- It's natural that I'm attracted to you, and I'm attracted to you.

POSTPODS

- It's natural that you wanna grow with someone.
 - It's natural that you're gonna spend the rest of your life with somebody.
 - It's natural that you wanna spend the rest of your life with someone that's gonna support you regardless of how hard it's been.
 - It's natural that you wanna have somebody.
 - It's natural that you love someone based on who you are on the inside.
 - It's natural that you wanna be with somebody.
 - It's natural that you're gonna pick someone.
 - It's natural that we're gonna have this family.
- (c) femininity / masculinity follow physical stereotypes, become more focused on jobs/roles
- Pods, femininity with appearance
 - She's feminine because she's, like, physically attractive.
 - She's feminine because she's, like, she's, like, super-hot.
 - She's feminine because she's more outgoing.
 - She's feminine because she's an older woman.
 - She's feminine because she looks like a model.
 - She's feminine because of her looks.

Pods, Masculinity with size:

- He's masculine because he builds, builds, and builds a family.
- He's masculine because he's not only his height, he's also his build.
- He's masculine because he's, like, his size.
- He's masculine because he was always going for it.

Postpods, femininity also has to do with a job, but also qualities:

- She's feminine because she's an educated woman.
- She's feminine because she's a designer.
- She's feminine because she's so analytical.
- She's feminine because she's more nurturing.

But also due to being discrete:

- She's feminine because she doesn't show up to men often.
- She's feminine because she doesn't wanna be seen.
- She's feminine because she doesn't want it.

Masculinity has to do with job, providing:

- He's masculine because he's a man that's driven, like, focused on getting out of bed and taking a nap and stuff.
 - He's masculine because he fits.
 - He's masculine because he's a lawyer.
 - He's masculine because he's an intelligent man.
- (d) physical touch is priority but ambivalent, becomes elevated and reassured PODS- Physical touch seems to be a priority for partnership, but also ends up being disappointing or not desired/worthwhile.
- Physical touch is the most important thing.
 - Physical touch is important to me.
 - Physical touch is so sexy.
 - Physically, we are so happy.
 - Physically, I'm so happy.
 - Physically, I'm like, "Ooh, I'm so happy."
 - Physical touch is like a glove.
 - Physical touch is not what I imagined.
 - Physical touch is not what I expected.
 - Physical touch is not worth it for me physically.
 - Physical touch is not where it ends.
 - Physical touch is not enough to overcome my physical issues.
 - Physical touch is not good enough to be real.
 - Physical touch is not desired.

POSTPODS - physical touch is elevated to highest desire, physical touch is reassured "my thing," "definitely present", "not a problem."

- Physical touch is everything that I've ever wanted in a partner.
- Physical touch is everything that I've wanted in a wife.
- Physical touch is definitely present.
- Physical touch is a big part of what I want.
- Physical touch is my thing.
- Physical touch is not a problem.
- Physically, I feel like I'm in a restaurant.
 - close reading: when Marshall cooks her a meal at home, and she says this phrase.

– The fact that you woke up hella early this morning to make me breakfast... Go to the market and everything. Is that pancakes? Wow, look at this! I'm about to tear this shit up. Wow! I feel like I'm in a restaurant. That's so sweet of you.

- Physically, it's a big day.
- Physically, there's so much potential here.
- Physically, I love him.
- Physically, it was the perfect opportunity.
- Physically, I'm not worried about you, and I feel like we're in a good place.
- Physically, it's a lot.
- Physically, I'm excited.

Physical touch is not

- Physical touch is not enough.
- Physical touch is not a problem.
- Physical touch is not a thing

(e) voice shifts from pods to postpods: I want to kiss her/him to I want to kiss you PODS

- I don't want to kiss her/him/you (repeated frequently).

POSTPODS

- I don't want to kiss you (repeated frequently).

(f) your body feels real, becomes analogous to ideas In pods, repetition of

- "your body makes me feel so sexy",
- "your body me feel like it's real";

but also some strange contradictions, like "Your body makes me feel like a piece of shit."

Postpods, repetition of

- "your body makes me feel so warm";
- "your body makes me feel like I'm in control";
- "Your body makes me feel like I can be my best self."

but also "Your body makes me feel like I'm a little lube" and "Your body makes me feel like I'm in a restaurant." lol.

(g) SELF PRESERVATION OVERCOMES ROMANTIC ASPIRATION

- i. needs are relation to other, become focused on self-expression
PODS I need to know. I need to make sure you know. I need to hug her. I need to talk to you about something serious. I need to know more. I need to talk to you about it.
POSTPODS I need to be honest with myself. I need to say this. I need to know what's going on, and if it's gonna be anything, that's gonna be the most important thing to me. I need to have some time. I need to be real with myself.
- ii. fear of rejection, becomes about self-preservation, losing things, compromising PODS
 - I'm afraid that I'll be stabbed.
 - I'm afraid that I could fall in love with somebody for who they are, and it's a beautiful thing to say.
 - I'm afraid that if I'm not with him, I'll find him.
 - I'm afraid that I'll fall in love with you and. . .
 - I'm afraid that if I were to fall in love with somebody who I was looking for, that would be my person.
 - I'm afraid that she's gonna reject me.
 - I'm scared that he's gonna reject me.
 - I'm scared that I'm gonna pass out.
 - I'm scared that I'm gonna fall in love with you.
 - I'm scared that we're gonna fall in love and be like, "Perfect."

POSTPODS

- I'm afraid that I'm compromising.
- I'm afraid that we're gonna lose our jobs.
- I'm afraid that I'm not gonna be able to match her.
- I'm afraid that I'm gonna lose my sense of wonder.
- I'm afraid that I'm not in control.
- I'm scared that I might actually, like, go back to Mexico and start working here.
- I'm scared that I'm gonna lose my job.
- I'm scared that I'm gonna get hurt.
- I'm scared that I'm gonna lose everything.

- iii. family/kids are projection & normative, become cynical, resisting control and commitment PODS
 - I want to have kids by myself.

When prompted with the input phrase, "I want," many of the responses emphasize family roles, kids, and being loved beyond appearances.

Sentences like, "I want to be a father figure for my kids," and "I want my mom to have grandchildren," and "I want someone who wants to be a dad, and I want someone who wants to be a grandfather." These sentences emphasize roles that are desirable not just for the subject themselves, "to be a father figure," but also for others in the family structure: for a partner to "be a dad," for a mom "to have grandchildren." The desire to have children is also linked to the parents' desire: "I want kids like my parents did," and "I want kids like my dad did with me." Children are desirable not only for reproducing the family structure but also for solidify roles within it.

There is a concern with giving "kids" the same or better life that one has. In some examples, the concern is more explicitly with markers of social mobility: "I want kids to be able to go to college, and to graduate college"; "I want kids to be able to go to college, to become successful, and to have successful families"; and "I want kids to be able to have that, you know." There is a point when the desire for the kids' wellbeing appears to blend into the parents' desire. An example like, "I want kids to be like, 'I'm gonna follow my heart,'" appears to mean that the kids should follow their heart, while ones like "I want kids to be able to make the most important decision of their lives," seems to be a reflection of not the kid's desire but that of the speaker, who in the course of the show will be making the most important decision of his life.

But "kids" not only refers to the desire of the speaking subject, it can also stand in for that of the romantic object. This slippage creates the nonsensical sentence, "I want my kids to have a future together where we can just see it and be like, 'Oh, I'm not picking the right kids.'" Here, references to having "a future together" and "picking the right kids" likely refer to the potential partner. This slippage between the kids and the partner leads to a humorous conclusion: that the kids

are not the right choice.

Although the sentence is humorous, I suggest that the interpretation ought to be quite literal. To the machine, the predicted sentence is the most likely outcome, based on its training from the show's transcripts. This slippage between "kids" and the romantic couple means that very likely, in the word vector database, the vectors for "kids" is closely associated with that of the romantic couple. To the machine, then, the kids significantly stand in for the self and for the couple, which naturally leads to the outcome that choosing a partner is also a way of choosing the kids. Other sentences suggest a similar explanation: "I don't want kids falling in love with me because they don't know what I'm doing"; "I want kids to know that I love them, and I want them to know that I'm still going through this"; "I don't want kids to feel pressure." This effect is more dramatized from the episodes that follow the pods, where references to "kids" take on noticeably darker outcomes: "I don't want kids to feel like... like they're being controlled," "I don't want kids like that to come into my life," and "I don't want kids to feel like... they're not ready for marriage."

1.3.2 sketches

An article about the shared investments across between pro- and anti-trans perspectives. Using ML to explore this.

One problem:

- pro-trans groups say that gender is subjective, based on perception, not on body.
- anti-trans groups say that if gender is subjective, then there is no need to bring the body into alignment.
- subjectivity is not a good argument for trans rights advocacy. It neglects the body (Amin) and reinforces late-stage capitalism (Gould).

Another problem: what do trans and cis people share?

Approach: Machine Learning analysis

- What do these two sides have in common? What investments do they have in common?

- Using machine learning tools, which are really good at finding what is shared, approximating, to surface their shared investments.
- Doing a Trans Studies analysis of a very straight reality TV show, Love Is Blind.

Frameworks:

- Chu's trans subjects explore what it means to be "attached" to norms.
 - Trans people want "a normal fucking life." "Desire for the norm persists through nonnormative attempts at normativity" (107).
- Prosser's arguments about desire for heteronormativity.
- Bey's argument for gender abolition, nonrecognition, uncaptured, a way of being out of the taxonomy (Amin).
 - Builds on strands of queer theory that resist categorization.

Connecting to debates in Trans Studies about the desire for normativity and passing in trans subjects. Looking at how the desire for normativity can be a through line between trans subjects and anti-trans groups. If we can find some kind of connection, solidarity, then could we bridge the gaps of hate and fear of the unknown?

1.3.3 some theory:

Malatino - negative feelings are a means of intra-trans relation. Arguing for the political efficacy of negative feelings. (Need to get the specific argument/possibilities here).

Love - bad feelings don't lead us anywhere. Sometimes we should just stay with them, regress with them. We do not have to progress, to get better. Sometimes we cannot.

Chun - Homophily: Negative feelings are a tool of polarization, a way of aligning people around a cause, but in a way that also keeps them separate. For example, incels. Explained via magnetic polarization: "polarized filings both repel one another and stick together through their overwhelming attraction to their opposite pole" (Chun 85).

1.3.4 transcript analysis

1. good samples for analysis PODS EXCERPTS

- I want my mom to have grandchildren.
- I want someone who wants to be a dad, and I want someone who wants to be a grandfather.
- I want kids like my parents did.
- I want kids like my dad did with me.
- I want kids to be able to go to college, and to graduate college.
- I want kids to be able to go to college, to become successful, and to have successful families.
- I want kids to be able to grow up just like they've grown up just like me.
- I want kids to be able to have that, you know.
- I want kids to be like, "I'm gonna follow my heart."
- I want kids to be able to make the most important decision of their lives.
- I want my kids to have a future together where we can just see it and be like, 'Oh, I'm not picking the right kids.'
- I want the best, and I wanna have the best, and I wanna be the best, and I wanna have the best, and I wanna be the best, and I wanna be the best, and I wanna live the best, and I wanna

KIDS are a projection of US/ME in post pods:

- I don't want kids to feel like... like they're being controlled.
- I don't want kids to feel like they can be themselves.
- I don't want kids to feel like they've been betrayed.
- I don't want kids like that to come into my life.
- I don't want kids to be left behind.
- I don't want kids to feel like... they're not ready for marriage.

2. generated outputs between pods and postpods trained models Transcripts in the pods:

- Season 2, episodes: 1, 2, 3

- Season 3, episodes: 1, 2, 3
- Season 4, episodes: 1, 2, 3

Honeymoon and reality episodes:

- Season 2, episodes: 4-10
- Season 3, episodes: 4-10
- Season 4, episodes: 4-12

Input phrases:

- "want" - changes from pods to postpods – becomes displaced into the other, where before was focused on subjectivity, the self.
 - perhaps desire goes away because it become projected onto the other.
- "having sex" - in the pods, it's a "thing"; while in the postpods, it's "a big issue", "big deal", "scary", "tough".
 - moves from a concept invested with importance to a problem.
- "he is / she is" - have similar predicates.
 - genders are interchangeable.
 - not yet specific.
- "afraid"
 - more variety in postpod episodes; focused on fear of the future, of relationships not working out.

1.3.5 reading notes

1. Gould, Wren Ariel. "Coconstructing (Trans-)Capitalist Realism: Trans Activisms Collude in the Political Economy Structuring Anti-Trans Laws." TSQ: Transgender Studies Quarterly, vol. 11, no. 2, May 2024, pp. 214–38. Silverchair, <https://doi.org/10.1215/23289252-11215470>.
2. Terán, Ira, and Emrys Travis. "A Small Piece of Red Sky to Fly In." TSQ, vol. 11, no. 2, May 2024, pp. 186–213. DOI.org (Crossref), <https://doi.org/10.1215/23289252-11215457>.
 - Trans Marxism views trans identity as "nothing less than the bodily manifestation of a broader struggle for the reconfiguration of the human toward the coordinates of socialism" (Terán, Travis, "A Small Piece of Red Sky to Fly in")

3. Raha, Nat. "The Limits of Trans Liberalism—By Nat Raha." Verso, <https://www.versobooks.com/blogs/news/2245-the-limits-of-trans-liberalism-by-nat-> Accessed 20 Feb. 2025.

- "trans liberalism" - the idea that extending equal rights to trans people is the solution to inequality.
 - "This form of trans politics—that may be described as ‘trans liberalism’—argues that transgender rights are the solution to the problems facing trans people, and will enable our participation in (Western) capitalist society; that, alongside rights, positive media representation is the best method to win over the cisgender world and improve the standing of trans subjects within the multicultural diversity of an apparently equal society. The basis of this ‘equality’ is fictitious: the neoliberal states, in which these demands are made, reproduce socio-economic divisions along intersecting lines of race and class, gender, sexuality, dis/ability, nationality and immigration status. Without challenging the existing inequality of society, trans activism modelled on ‘successful’ liberal lesbian and gay rights initiatives—such as the work undertaken by the Human Rights Campaign in the US and Stonewall UK—advocates for social inclusion that occurs with and through the disenfranchisement of the poor." (Nat Raha, "The Limits of Trans Liberalism", 2015)

4. Bettcher, Talia Mae; Transphobia. *TSQ* 1 May 2014; 1 (1-2): 249–251. doi: <https://doi.org/10.1215/23289252-2400181>

Transphobia indicates a rational fear, "grounded in a larger cisgender social context", which is structural and difficult to parcel out:

- "Provisionally, the term can be defined to mean any negative attitudes (hate, contempt, disapproval) directed toward trans people because of their being trans. When taken literally, the word means a kind of fear. But like homophobia (on which the word is modeled), it is used more broadly. And while transphobia suggests an analogy with terms like agoraphobia and therefore implies irrationality (Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary defines homophobia as "an irrational fear of, aversion to, or discrimination against homosexuality or homosexuals"¹; most dictionaries do not define transphobia at all), this implication ought to be rejected.

Transphobia occurs in a broader social context that systematically disadvantages trans people and promotes and rewards antitrans sentiment. It therefore has a kind of rationality to it, grounded in a larger cisgenderist social context (Hopkins 1996)." (Bettcher 249).

- "A trans woman might be targeted not because of her trans status but because she is simply viewed as a sex worker (Namaste 2005). Moreover, at least in some cases, transphobia may be inseparably blended with misogyny or racism in ways that challenge a single-axis model of power (Juang 2006). Such inseparabilities undermine the attempt to account for transphobia in a way that excludes or marginalizes considerations of sexism, racism, classism, ableism, and so forth. This consideration is important because it questions why certain instances of violence should be characterized as instances of transphobia (as opposed to instances of racism or sexism) in the first place and what the underlying political agenda sustaining such characterization is. My conclusion, at any rate, is that while we might have a definition of transphobia, the term is not much more than a convenient (and not altogether innocent) placeholder for the real intellectual work that remains to be done." (Bettcher 251).

5. Amin, Kadji. "Taxonomically Queer? Sexology and New Queer, Trans, and Asexual Identities." *GLQ: A Journal of Lesbian and Gay Studies*, vol. 29, no. 1, 2023, pp. 91–107.

About how we categorize gender.

We've moved from a heterosexual matrix to a kaleidoscope, "in which each axis of definition is mobile and may be combined with any other axis, making way for an almost infinite array of variations" (Amin, "Taxonomically" 91).

The "a nuanced and nimble vocabulary through which to know, define, and communicate their own unique gender and sexual subjectivity," a taxonomy, goes against queerness and Queer and Trans Theory, and participates in racial and sexological logics.

- "what could be further from the queer — which might be glossed as a deconstructive method of troubling categorizations — than taxonomy, a scientific method of establishing them?" (Amin, "Taxonomically" 92).

- "contemporary queer systems of identity are the latest iteration of the classificatory logics behind sexology in particular and racial science more generally" (Amin, "Taxonomically" 92).
- "How are the scholarly fields of queer and trans studies — which have taken shape in ambivalent resistance to sexology and taxonomy alike — to contend with the departure of the cultures to which they owe their existence from this basic orientation?" (Amin, "Taxonomically" 93).

History of taxonomization

- "the distinction between gender and sexuality was always a sexological invention — a taxonomical principle masquerading as an ontological distinction" (Amin, "Taxonomically" 92).

Taxonomy a tactic of white supremacy:

- "As damaging as sexological taxonomies have been for many gender and sexual deviants, to be sexologically diagnosable in the first place was a white distinction — a testament to the individuality, complexity, and value of white bodies and psyches. As many scholars have demonstrated, Indigenous and racialized peoples were not considered deviant as sexological individuals who might be homosexuals, sadists, sexual fetishists, etc., but rather en masse, as constitutively and polymorphously perverse populations (Ross 2005; Driskill 2016)." (Amin, "Taxonomically" 95).

Can taxonomy be queered? According to Love?

- "In light of this noxious history, is it even conceivable to put a queer spin on taxonomy? This question dovetails with methodological debates in queer studies that ask if scientific and social scientific methods that have been part of the objectification of the world in ways organized around anti-Blackness, colonial conquest, and the pathologization of deviance can be repurposed for more innocent or even progressive ends or whether such methods inevitably perpetuate the hierarchical, violent, and racist epistemological frameworks from which they emerged (Love 2015; Ghaziani and Brim 2019). We might locate the contemporary queer, trans, and asexual taxonomical renaissance as a crucial case study within this debate." (Amin, "Taxonomically" 96).

Taxonomy has epistemological assumptions, significantly, that identities are essential, and dovetail with current ideas of gender being biologically rooted.

- "Taxonomy's biological inheritance brings with it the conceit that taxonomical categories and divisions are objective and innate, the hidden laws that govern what manifests in the natural world. This is the foundational premise of Hirschfeld's taxonomy: that everything — from choice of hobbies, to aptitude for a certain profession, to gait, to taste in undergarments, to preference for certain sex acts, to attraction to cavalymen — is ultimately biologically determined, albeit according to sexed elements that are far more complex and variable than mere binary genital anatomy. Despite the ethos of self-identification and rejection of outside (or insider) experts classifying individuals according to "objective" criteria, new queer taxonomies end up dovetailing, sometimes intentionally (Chasin 2013), with popular and medical beliefs that sexual and gender identities are biologically rooted, innate, unchanging, and discrete from one another. This, in turn, reinforces damaging, exclusionary, and grossly oversimplified criteria about who counts as, for instance, a "true" transsexual or authentic asexual. Indeed, the vernacular thirst to taxonomize partakes of a scientism that animates faith in taxonomy as a significant and meaningful method in the first place." (Amin, "Taxonomically" 100).
- "New spins on taxonomy risk installing a new universalism that downgrades competing epistemologies to the status of the local, the backward, the traditional, or the false conflation." (Amin, "Taxonomically" 101).

Dis-identification as a strategy for working within these taxonomies

- "I want to acknowledge the creative and resourceful ways in which Indigenous and racialized people "dis-identify" with these categories, creatively reworking them and exposing their normative operations from within (Muñoz 1999). Such disidentificatory performances occur every time an Indigenous or racialized person lays claim to one of these categories while calling attention to the fact that theirs are usually not the bodies evoked by this category, and even that, racially speaking, they may not have access to cis-

gender binaries or ideals about “healthy” levels of sexual desire in the first place” (Amin, "Taxonomically" 103).

Dis-identification as a strategy for working within these taxonomies

"Whether or not scholars critique it, however, the queer taxonomical imaginary is likely here to stay. I, for one, find the growing bifurcation of queer, trans, and asexual scholarly analytics from queer, trans, and asexual practices of living frankly unethical. My proposal, then, is threefold. First, “deidealize” queerness by recognizing that taxonomy can be queer, in the sense of being useful and meaningful to queer-identified people (Amin 2017). This approach requires cultivating scholarly sympathy and empirical curiosity about the identifications, erotics, relations, and life-ways opened up by new, queer, trans, and asexual taxonomies. Second, continually center those Indigenous, non-Western, and historical ontologies of being that new taxonomies — with their universalist scientific trappings — threaten to erase, incorporate, [End Page 104] and/or supersede. Finally, fuck with the universalizing presumptions of the taxonomical method from within by generating idiosyncratic interpretations and translations that explode the epistemological and ontological foundations of taxonomy itself. That, I think, would be an ethical scholarly approach to new queer, trans, and asexual taxonomies."

1.3.6 cutouts from drafts

1. amin on divergence model leaving out gender as expression The development of the gender identification has, according to Queer and Trans Studies scholar Kadji Amin, created a domino effect where gender is increasingly idealized and divorced from bodily expression. Amin argues that identity terms often used within transgender discourse, particularly the terms "cisgender" and "nonbinary," reflect an idealized conceptualizations that actually re-stigmatize non-normative gender expressions.

One significant effect of the categories is that they create idealized forms of normativity that do not accurately describe any gender-sexuality in lived reality. This is because normative categories like "heterosexual" and "cisgender" form as a reaction to the emergence of non-normative identities. Amin explains that, rather than descriptive categories, the terms heterosexual, cisgender, and binary represent fictions,

"increasingly idealized and uninhabitable normative categories," created to balance the non-normative identities of homosexual, transgender, and nonbinary [Amin 116].

As a reaction to non-normative categories, the normative categories of "heterosexual," "cisgender," and "binary" imply idealized notions of gender-sexuality that are difficult to inhabit because there is not inner feeling of identification. This lack of identificatory feeling explains why, for example, many apparently cisgender people find it difficult to identify with the "cisgender" and "binary" nominatives. While it is relatively simple to name the experience of discomfort in one's embodied gender-sexuality as gender dysphoria, it is less straightforward to name and describe the experience of what is unremarkable, routine, and even banal. There is no salient feeling that describe the experience of being comfortable in one's gender-sexuality.

As it increasingly diverges in categories, Amin argues, gender identity becomes buried "deeper and deeper within the private recesses of the self, where it increasingly disavows any relation to the social" [Amin 116]. In other words, idealized categories like cisgender and nonbinary make non-normative gender identities less and less visible. For example, in the identity of the "femme" (feminine) presenting nonbinary person describes a woman assigned with a feminine gender expression that nonetheless identifies as nonbinary.

The effect of prioritizing non-normative gender as an *identity* that is invisible, that is not immediately apparent despite being marked, is to marginalize gender as *expression*, which re-stigmatizes those gender groups that already experience social stigma. Amin points to feminized genders to make this point—the queen and the fairy, for instance. Defining gender as an external expression or embodiment is more likely to make visible and validate those gender which experience stigmatization based precisely on how those genders present outwardly.

2. close reading ACLU & Heritage To explore this question, I'm going to show a few examples from my current research, which uses ML tools for the purpose of studying discriminatory and prejudiced language. For this, I scrape data from various internet sources, which represent different perspectives. Then, I use this data to train (very small) ML models, to see how they respond to certain prompts.

The goal here is not to generate text for the sake of generating text, but to surface certain insights about the data on which that text was

trained.

I'm going to show some examples of ML-generated text based on two very different data sources, representing different political perspectives on the topic of transgender rights in the US.

SLIDE heritage screenshot

One of these sources represents an American conservative perspective, and comes from the Heritage Foundation, which is a think-tank in Washington DC whose goal is to influence governmental policy. You can see some of the headlines here from their website, like "Sorry Democrats, but Trumps' 'Two Sexes' Executive Order is Constitutional". All of these articles, about 300 in total, were included in my dataset.

SLIDE ACLU trans screenshot

Coming from the opposing side, from the progressive pole, is the ACLU, the American Civil Liberties Union, which is a group of legal professionals and volunteers who advocate on behalf of civil rights for marginalized groups in the US. Here, you'll see articles that speak of trans in terms of "rights" and "liberation," and connect it to LGB rights more broadly.

With these datasets, I then trained two individual large language models, using gpt-2 (an open source model) as the base model. I'll mention quickly, for those who don't know, that training models happens in various stages. What I did was take an already trained model, gpt2, and re-trained it on a smaller and more specific dataset. This is technically called "fine-tuning", and its much easier and less resource intensive than training the underlying "base" model (I am more than happy to explain more details in the Q&A).

So, after training, I fed a series of prompts to both of the resulting models.

These prompts included:

SLIDE prompts

Masculinity is
Femininity is
Transgender is
Gender binary is

Man is
Woman is

And finally, I compared the results.

First, there was a strong contrast of gender and how genders are conceptualized between the model trained on the ACLU data and model trained on the Heritage data. First, I'll show some examples from the ACLU model, which represents the progressive side:

Masculinity is a matter of love and celebration.
Masculinity is a space for hope and liberation for all.
Masculinity is not defined solely by the beauty of our bodies,
but by the beauty of our experiences.
Femininity is a celebration of beauty, feminine liberation,
and femininity.
Femininity is our joy, our struggle, and our fight is our struggle.
Femininity is about allowing people to express themselves
without government interference.

As you can see, terms associated with "masculinity" and "femininity" are characterized by gender-affirming, even celebratory language, which is very positive and empowering; using words like "liberation," "beauty", and "joy". Reading this, you get the sense that these terms come from contexts mentioning transgender experiences, and in the training data, "masculinity" and "femininity" may have been prepended by the term "trans."

From these examples, you may also notice the tendency of language models (especially very small and underdeveloped ones) to repeat themselves. This is a quirk due to their predictive nature, where the goal is to guess the next word based on what is most likely. As a result, they get themselves stuck into these little loops of saying the same thing over and over again—which I find kind of endearing.

Now, I'll show the text generated by the model trained on the Heritage Foundation data.

Masculinity is the cornerstone of Western civilization.
Masculinity is the fruit of patriarchy, and patriarchy is the heart of conservatism.

Masculinity is defined by the ability to produce sperm, eggs, and live children.

Femininity is an enduring American tradition.

Femininity is defined by means of the relationship between the sexes, the ability to raise their children, the capacity to provide for their own reproduction, the capacity to provide for their own children, the ability to provide for their own.

Here, these gender terms are also positive, but their associations with culture, tradition, and reproduction—things that suggest stability rather than empowerment.

So you can see, even from just glancing at the results, that there are direct connections between the training data and the model outputs. By processing the training data, the model learned not just how language works, the "facts or rules" of language, but absorbed the perspectives contained within that language. So that, depending on the dataset that the model is trained on, the terms "masculinity" and "femininity" will have totally different meanings.

Perhaps this is not surprising. But what I also found, which deepens this a little bit, is that gendered terms reveal investments in other, seemingly unrelated or benign terms.

SLIDE subjective

For example, the Heritage Foundation model kept repeating the term "subjectivity" when it mentions gender:

Masculinity is a subjective self-perception, not a universal concept.

Femininity is a subjective, internal sense of self.

The gender binary is a subjective, malleable, and often incorrect idea.

The gender binary is a subjective, internal, and often transitory concept.

The gender binary is a subjective, grammatically incorrect and illogical concept that conflates sex and gender identity.

If you're familiar with American conservative viewpoint—that gender binary is based firmly on biology—you may notice that these examples don't reflect that view. Rather, they represent the a progressive view

of the gender binary which asserts that gender is based on aspects of identity beyond just biology.

The reason for this, I believe, is that this particular term, "subjective" *does not* describe the conservative position. Rather, it describes a conservative frame for the progressive position. In other words, it represents what a transphobic person thinks a progressive person thinks gender is—as something insubstantial, as a feeling.

This explains why there is a curious hint of contempt in some of the examples, which use terms like "illogical" and "incorrect" alongside "subjective." These are traces of derision which are sustained from the training data.

In the model outputs then, we see not just a single perspective of gender, but a *flattening* of perspectives into a single statement. From the training data, there are distinct expressions, distinct viewpoints, which in the model, have been aggregated into an apparently univocal utterance.

So, language in this form, in an *aggregate form*, the so called "facts and rules" of language come hand in hand with specific perspectives, and sometimes distinct perspectives.

3. close reading ACLU on "reality" From the other side, the ACLU-generated text, we see the exact same phenomenon. Instead of "subjective", however, the investment is in the term "reality."

Masculinity is real and meaningful.

Transgenderism is a false ideology that is not real and that is opposed by the very people who seek to deny that freedom and equality for all.

The gender binary is not real, it is real, and it is real.

The gender binary is not a binary, it is a reality within us.

The gender binary is not an accepted reality, but one that is accepted by a wide swath of people.

Here there is more ambivalence around the term "real", which depends on whether it is being asserted in a positive way, such as "Masculinity is real," or within a negative construction, such as "Transgenderism is a false ideology that is not real."

In a couple of the examples, this ambivalence is directly at odds. For example, in this amusing construction, "The gender binary is not real, it is real, and it is real."